

Chapter 3: An Unexpected Apology

Jenny stared at Austin Blackwood.

For a moment, she wondered if she had heard him correctly.

The richest trader in Silver Harbor was standing behind the restaurant.

Alone.

At night.

And apparently trying to apologize.

This had to be a joke.

She narrowed her eyes.

"Are you lost?"

Austin blinked.

"What?"

"The harbor is that way."

She pointed toward the city lights.

"The rich people district."

His lips twitched slightly.

Not quite a smile.

But close.

"I know where I live."

"Then why are you here?"

Austin looked away briefly.

As if searching for the right words.

That surprised Jenny more than anything.

Men like him always seemed to know exactly what to say.

"I may have overreacted."

Jenny almost choked.

"May have?"

Austin sighed.

"Fine. I overreacted."

"There it is."

"There what is?"

"The apology."

He frowned.

"I wasn't apologizing."

Jenny laughed.

"Sure."

Austin immediately regretted coming.

This was a terrible idea.

Yet somehow he stayed.

Usually, when he left a business dispute, he never thought about it again.

But Jenny had occupied his thoughts all evening.

Not because she was beautiful.

Though she was.

Not because she was interesting.

Though she was.

It was because she wasn't afraid of him.

That was rare.

Dangerously rare.

Most people saw his money before they saw him.

Jenny saw neither.

She only saw an arrogant customer.

And she treated him accordingly.

"You really don't know who I am, do you?" he asked.

Jenny shrugged.

"You're Austin Blackwood."

"And?"

"A wealthy trader."

"And?"

She frowned.

"What other answer are you looking for?"

Austin stared at her.

People usually listed his achievements.

His properties.

His investments.

His influence.

Jenny couldn't care less.

For some reason, he found that refreshing.

And annoying.

Mostly annoying.

A comfortable silence settled between them.

Then Jenny's stomach growled.

Loudly.

Very loudly.

She immediately closed her eyes.

Wonderful.

Perfect timing.

Austin raised an eyebrow.

Jenny pretended nothing happened.

Austin raised both eyebrows.

Jenny sighed.

"Don't."

"Don't what?"

"Say whatever rich-person comment you're thinking."

"I'm not thinking anything."

"That's a lie."

His lips twitched again.

This time it definitely looked like a smile.

Jenny hated that she noticed.

"Have you eaten?" he asked.

She pointed to the instant noodles beside her.

"Obviously."

"That isn't food."

"It is when you're poor."

The words slipped out before she could stop them.

Silence followed.

Austin's expression changed.

Just slightly.

The arrogance faded.

For a brief moment, something softer appeared.

Jenny immediately regretted saying it.

She hated pity.

More than anything.

"I don't need sympathy," she said.

"I wasn't offering sympathy."

"Good."

"I was offering dinner."

Jenny blinked.

"What?"

"Dinner."

Austin nodded toward the restaurant.

"Proper food."

She stared at him.

"Are you trying to bribe me?"

"No."

"It feels like a bribe."

"It's not."

"Then it's weird."

Austin rubbed his forehead.

"Do you always argue this much?"

"Only when people deserve it."

"Interesting."

"What is?"

"You assume most people deserve it."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Experience taught me that."

The words carried more weight than she intended.

Austin noticed.

But for once, he didn't push.

Instead, he glanced at the message still open on her phone.

The one from her mother.

Jenny quickly locked the screen.

Too late.

He had already seen enough.

Medical expenses.

Family problems.

Money troubles.

Things he knew nothing about.

Or perhaps things he had forgotten.

Because once upon a time, before the wealth and luxury, Austin's family hadn't been rich either.

That felt like a lifetime ago.

"You support your family?" he asked.

Jenny hesitated.

Then nodded.

"My parents."

"And your siblings?"

She laughed bitterly.

"Mostly just my parents."

Austin studied her face.

The exhaustion around her eyes.

The worn-out sneakers.

The determination she carried like armor.

For the first time, he began to understand why she fought so hard.

Why she refused to back down.

People with nothing to lose could afford to be reckless.

People with everything depending on them could not.

"You work too much," he said.

Jenny almost laughed.

"And you spend too much."

That earned a genuine smile.

A real one.

Brief.

But real.

The sight caught her off guard.

It changed him completely.

For a second, he looked younger.

Less cold.

Less alone.

The realization made her uncomfortable.

Very uncomfortable.

Fortunately, Bao chose that exact moment to burst through the back door.

"There you are!"

He stopped.

His eyes widened.

Then widened even more.

"Oh."

Jenny immediately knew what he was thinking.

And she hated it.

"It's not what it looks like."

Bao looked between them.

"Then what does it look like?"

"Nothing."

Bao grinned.

"It definitely looks like something."

Austin looked amused.

That made everything worse.

Jenny pointed toward the restaurant.

"Go back inside."

"But—"

"Now."

Bao retreated.

Still grinning.

The door closed.

Silence returned.

Austin checked the time.

"I should go."

"Good."

His eyebrow lifted.

"Good?"

"The city might collapse if you're away from your money too long."

To her surprise, he laughed.

Actually laughed.

The sound was low and warm.

Completely different from the man who had demanded her firing.

Jenny found herself staring.

Austin noticed.

Their eyes met.

For a brief second, neither looked away.

Something shifted.

Small.

Almost invisible.

But undeniable.

The air suddenly felt different.

Dangerous.

Austin cleared his throat first.

"I'll see you around, Jenny."

She frowned.

"Hopefully not."

His smile returned.

"I don't think you're that lucky."

Then he walked away.

Jenny watched him disappear into the night.

Only after he was gone did she realize something.

For the first time since meeting Austin Blackwood...

She hadn't wanted him to leave.

And that thought scared her far more than his anger ever had.